

UNBOUND

The Social System



Words are weapons. Resources spent in argument are as real as resources spent in battle.

RHabit Game Development

PART I — PHILOSOPHY AND FRAMEWORK

Core Design Principles

The social system uses the same mechanical skeleton as combat. The same turn structure, the same action economy, the same resource pools, the same status effect vocabulary. What changes is what the actions represent and which resources take primary damage.

In combat, HP takes primary damage. In social encounters, SP and MP take primary damage. A character who runs out of SP has lost their nerve. A character who runs out of MP has lost their clarity and focus. When either pool hits zero the encounter may need to pause and resume later, or the character may concede depending on context. Running out of SP or MP does not automatically mean the other party wins.

Social skills can be used in combat to drain enemy resources and apply status effects. Combat events carry into social encounters. A character who has been physically intimidated carries Demoralize stacks into the negotiation that follows. The two modes bleed into each other because in reality they always do.

On Status Effects

Most status effects apply equally in combat and social encounters. Slow in combat is a fighter moving through mud. Slow in a social encounter is a speaker who cannot find words quickly enough. Demoralize, Confuse, Fear, Exhaust, Inspire, Charmed — all transfer directly. The vocabulary is shared because the underlying human experience is shared.

Resource Economy in Social Encounters

Social actions using BDY or SPT cost 1 SP. Social actions using MND cost 1 MP. Casual conversation with no mechanical intent costs nothing and produces no mechanical effect.

All social actions allow a free defense roll when targeted. If the attacker wins the roll, it affects Rapport with the defender. If the successful action was offensive, the defender loses resource from the pool associated with the Stat used to defend. A failed defense against a SPT-based attack costs the defender SP. A failed defense against a MND-based attack costs the defender MP.

Defense Tokens work the same way as in combat. Spend 1 AP to generate a Defense Token. Spend that token to make a defense roll when targeted by a social action. Without a token the action lands without opposition. In combat, countering a social action costs the same resource as blocking or dodging.

Social Criticals and Tags

A social critical occurs when the attack roll exceeds the defense roll by 10 or more — the same threshold as combat criticals. Social criticals deal double the margin as resource damage and apply one relevant status effect.

Social critical successes and critical failures both produce Knowledge Tags, following the same pipeline as combat and crafting crits. The Tag describes demonstrated social capability:

Action	Critical Tag Produced
Inspire	[Inspiring T1]
Seduce	[Seductive T1]
Persuade	[Persuasive T1]
Deceive	[Deceptive T1]
Intimidate	[Intimidating T1]
Insight	[Perceptive T1]
Investigate	[Investigative T1]
Resolve (defense)	[Resolute T1]

These Tags feed into skill prerequisites at higher tiers. A Tier 2 Intimidation skill might require [Intimidating T2] plus a relevant physical or authority Tag. The Tags are earned through demonstrated use, not through study.

Momentum in Pure Social Encounters

In combat, social actions operate within the normal initiative order. In purely social encounters — conversations, negotiations, debates, court interactions with no active combat — Momentum tracks who controls the frame of the interaction.

At the start of a pure social encounter, all participants make a Momentum roll: SPT dice plus any relevant social skill flat bonus. The highest roll goes first. A social critical during the encounter allows the attacker to move one position up in the Momentum order immediately. Momentum is not initiative and does not transfer to combat if the encounter escalates.

When SP or MP Runs Out

Depleting SP or MP in a social encounter does not automatically produce a winner. Context determines the outcome:

- **Nerve exhausted (SP = 0):** The character may need to step away and collect themselves. The conversation may need to pause. If cornered with no escape, they may concede to terms.
- **Clarity exhausted (MP = 0):** The character cannot maintain their rational position. They may need time to think. If pressed immediately, they may accept the argument or become confused about their own stance.
- **Forced concession:** Only occurs when the character has no recourse — no allies, no exit, no time. Cannot be forced to concede to anything requiring action against their deepest values or causing serious self-harm.

PART II — THE CHAKRA COSMOLOGY

The social skill system is grounded in a seven-chakra framework that reflects the developmental arc of emotional and social understanding. Characters learn the surface actions first. Deeper understanding of the chakra dynamic comes through sustained investment. The cosmological layer — Love, Loss, Fate, Will, Truth, Change, Memory — is what masters and grandmasters operate from.

The Seven Chakras

Chakra	Bridge	Domain	Virtue	Vice	Novice Social Skill
Root	Loss	Survival — the foundation’s greatest fear. Loss is what gives the root level its weight. What you have can be lost. That possibility is why it matters.	Charity	Gluttony	Survival
Sacral	Change	Desire — the generative current. Chastity directs desire inward toward higher development. Lust seeks external satisfaction. Change is inevitable and both are responses to it.	Chastity	Lust	Desire
Solar Plexus	Will	Power — the body’s battery. Charity flows from genuine sufficiency. Greed is the signal of an empty or uncertain battery. Will is the force that acts on the world.	Temperance	Greed	Willpower
Heart	Love	Love — the center. Forgiveness is Love’s restorative force. Wrath is Love’s corrective force — the feedback that sometimes has to hurt to help. Both are expressions of the same center.	Forgiveness	Wrath	Courage
Throat	Truth	Truth — truth surfaces regardless. Diligence investigates and illuminates. Sloth withholds, delays, or waits for truth to surface through others.	Diligence	Sloth	Discovery
Third Eye	Fate	Perception — physical and metacognitive. Kindness is compassion born from genuinely perceiving the threads of fate on another. Envy is the desire for the fate that befell another.	Kindness	Envy	Observation
Crown	Memory	Memory — Humility remembers the limits of what you know. Pride is the assurance of what you do know. Both are valid. Wisdom is knowing which the moment calls for.	Humility	Pride	Wisdom

The Vice and Virtue Switching Mechanic

In previous versions of the system, investing in one polarity drained marks from the other. This has been removed. Both the Virtue and Vice of each chakra pair accumulate marks independently. A character may invest in both.

At Tier 1, Virtue and Vice are separate skills. At Tier 2, when both have been developed, the character gains access to the switching mechanic: during upkeep, they declare which expression is active. The active expression's bonuses apply. The inactive expression's levels are held but dormant.

This creates a forms-based playstyle. A Forgiveness/Wrath character who reads a social encounter failing can flip to Wrath during upkeep and the next round operates completely differently. The person who was defending against patient Forgiveness suddenly faces raw force. The tactical depth is significant without requiring new mechanical systems.

Example

A character with Forgiveness Level 3 and Wrath Level 2 is currently in Forgiveness mode — calm, patient, creating space for resolution. The negotiation is failing. During upkeep they switch to Wrath. Their Wrath flat bonus now applies instead of Forgiveness. The Intimidate action they use this round carries the full force of their Wrath investment. They switch back to Forgiveness next upkeep once the point has been made.

Emotional Affinities and Social Skills

Emotional Affinities are the magical expression of the same emotional channels that social skills develop through purely human means. They are parallel tracks, not the same track.

Social skills are the mundane versions of what Affinities do in the magical domain. They are of nearly equal power within the social scene as Affinities are in combat — both cost the same XP, though with different buy-in requirements. A Grandmaster social character who has zero Affinity investment is a king, a president, a warlord — someone who solves kingdom-tier problems through human understanding alone.

Affinities augment social skills where both are held. A character with Wrath Affinity Level 3 who also has Intimidate Level 3 is drawing on the same Heart channel through two different systems simultaneously. The social skill gives technique and precision. The Affinity gives raw force that manifests as genuine magical pressure. The two amplify each other without either requiring the other.

Social skills do not reach into Bridge Affinity territory on their own. The Bridge energies — Love, Loss, Fate, Will, Truth, Change, Memory — are Affinity territory. A social character who also has the corresponding Bridge Affinity operates at both the mundane and magical level of that channel simultaneously. Without the Affinity, the social skill operates fully within the human domain and does not access the Bridge.

PART III — BASE SOCIAL ACTIONS

Six social actions are available to any character regardless of skill investment. These are the raw, unskilled versions of social capability — what any person can attempt using their Stats alone. Skills improve these actions, make them more reliable and powerful, and unlock effects the unskilled version cannot reach.

A character without skill investment rolls their governing Stat dice with no flat bonus. The action produces a basic version of the described effect on success.

Action	Governing Stat	Basic Effect	Defense Costs
Inspire	SPT	Apply 1 Inspiration stack to target. Target gains SP equal to their next AP spent.	SP to defend
Seduce	SPT or BDY	Create desire for what you offer — yourself, an idea, an object, an experience. A merchant seduces a customer. Apply Enthralled 1 stack on success.	SP to defend
Persuade	SPT (emotional) or MND (logical)	Convince target of something or toward a course of action. Generate Rapport equal to margin on success.	SP or MP to defend
Deceive	MND (construct) or SPT (conceal)	Create a false impression. Apply Disorient 1 stack on success. If discovered later, Rapport decreases by original margin plus discovery margin.	MP to defend
Intimidate	Highest of BDY, SPT, or MND	Apply fear through power, consequence, or force of personality. Apply Fear 1 stack on success. Apply Demoralize on critical.	SP to defend
Insight	SPT	Read what is actually happening beneath the surface. Detect an active Deceive attempt on success. Identify dominant emotional state of target as free action.	MP to defend

On Seduce

Seduce is the act of making something irresistible — creating desire for whatever is being offered. The word carries no inherent sexual meaning in this system. A merchant who makes their wares seem absolutely necessary is seducing the customer. A diplomat who frames a treaty as obviously beneficial seduces the other party toward agreement. The sexual application is one narrow expression of a much broader social force.

Investigate and Resolve

Two additional actions exist that are primarily defensive or environmental rather than interpersonal:

Action	Governing Stat	Basic Effect
Investigate	MND or SPT	Active search of immediate surroundings. Find hidden objects, information, traps, concealed people, or anything within close range. MND for methodical search, SPT for intuitive sweep.

Action	Governing Stat	Basic Effect
Resolve	SPT or MND	Hold your position under social pressure. Social defense action. Resist Intimidate, Persuade, and Seduce attempts. On success, apply Determination 1 stack — the character's conviction strengthens under pressure.

PART IV — SOCIAL SKILL TREES

Structure Overview

Social skills are built in tiers that reflect the real-world order in which people develop social understanding. The surface actions come first. The deeper patterns come later. Most characters will develop Tier 1 and 2 skills and find them fully sufficient. Tier 3 and beyond represent serious specialization.

Tier	Scope	Prerequisite	Examples
Tier 1 — Base Skills	The six base social actions as learnable skills. Broad. Immediately useful.	None	Inspire, Persuade, Intimidate, Insight, Deceive, Investigate
Tier 2 — Specializations	Specific expressions of each base skill. Narrower, deeper, more powerful within their domain.	Tier 1 Level 2 in relevant skill	Reason/Debate, Barter, Presence, Concealment, Observe, Search
Tier 3 — Deep Specializations	Specific contexts, target types, or combined techniques.	Tier 2 Level 2 in relevant skill	Leadership (from Inspiring), Rhetoric, Misrepresentation
Tier 4 — Mastery	Complete mastery of a social domain.	Tier 3 Level 3	Grand Diplomat, Master Deceiver
Tier 5 — Grandmaster	Kingdom-tier social capability. Solves civilization-scale problems.	Tier 4 Level 4 in multiple tracks	Grandmaster Social Mastery

The Seven Novice Social Skills

The seven Novice social skills map onto the chakra framework and each cover two of the base social actions within their domain. These are the broadest tier — developing one of these gives a flat bonus to both social actions it covers and provides the standard Level 2 resource pool increase.

Novice Skill	Chakra	Primary Actions	Domain
Survival	Root / Loss	Resolve, Investigate	Basic necessities, what you do with what you have, generosity versus hoarding at the survival level.
Desire	Sacral / Change	Seduce, Resolve	The engine of change. What you want and how you pursue or restrain it. Seduction of all kinds.
Willpower	Solar Plexus / Will	Persuade, Inspire	Defend and leverage. Protection of others versus extraction from them. The will expressed as shield or as hook.
Courage	Heart / Love	Inspire, Intimidate	To forgive or to avenge. The ability to stand against something or force change through fear.

Novice Skill	Chakra	Primary Actions	Domain
Discovery	Throat / Truth	Investigate, Resolve	Finding truth and deciding whether to reveal or conceal it. Active search. Standing firm on what you've found.
Observation	Third Eye / Fate	Insight, Investigate	Noticing what others miss. Detecting surveillance. Threat sensing. Perceiving at distance through sound, smell, motion.
Wisdom	Crown / Memory	Insight, Persuade	Learning from others and projecting what you know. Social defense through self-knowledge. Diplomacy through accumulated understanding.

Tier 2 Skill Trees

Each base social skill branches into Tier 2 specializations. These require Level 2 in the relevant Tier 1 skill. A character chooses which branch to invest in based on how they want to express that social capability.

Inspire → Tier 2 Branches

Tier 2 Skill	Domain	Notes
Inspiring	General motivational leadership before formal command structure	The sergeant has Inspiring. The lieutenant requires Leadership built on top of it.
String Instruments	Lutes, lyres, harps, bowed strings	Inspire through string performance. Each instrument family is its own Tier 2.
Percussion Instruments	Drums, bells, struck instruments	Inspire through rhythm and percussive performance.
Wind Instruments	Flutes, horns, pipes, reeds	Inspire through breath and wind performance.
Choreography	Dance and physical performance	Inspire through movement. SPT or BDY depending on approach.
Storytelling	Oral narrative tradition	Inspire through story. The oldest performance form.

Seduce → Tier 2 Branches

Tier 2 Skill	Domain	Notes
Social Seduction	Making yourself irresistible as a person	Charm, allure, personal magnetism in social contexts.
Intellectual Seduction	Making ideas irresistible	Presenting a concept so compellingly that the other party wants to believe it or act on it.
Aesthetic Seduction	Making experiences or objects irresistible	The artist, the designer, the chef — making what you create impossible to resist.

Persuade → Tier 2 Branches

Tier 2 Skill	Domain	Notes
Debate	Intellectual exchange. Structured argument using Reason.	One on one or small group. Logic, evidence, and structured counter-argument. Knowledge Tags in the relevant topic create floors and ceilings on effectiveness.
Negotiate	Political exchange. Mutual concession finding terms both parties can accept.	Requires both parties willing to engage. Produces binding social agreements when successful.
Rhetoric	Appealing to masses. Crowd-scale persuasion.	Public speaking, oratory, the ability to move large groups. Generates Rapport with multiple targets simultaneously.

Deceive → Tier 2 Branches

Tier 2 Skill	Domain	Notes
Concealment	Omission, hiding truth, misdirection without lying directly	What you don't say. What you make invisible. Silence as a form of deception. Hiding objects, people, or information in plain sight.
Lying	Presenting false information as truth	Direct false statements delivered convincingly. The construction and maintenance of a specific false belief in the target.
Misrepresentation	Disguise, theatre, exaggeration, understatement	Altering how something true appears. The actor, the spy with a cover identity, the salesperson who exaggerates benefits. Truth distorted rather than replaced.

Intimidate → Tier 2 Branches

Tier 2 Skill	Domain	Notes
Presence	Physical size, bearing, demonstrated capability	The barbarian. Power that comes from what the body communicates. Effective anywhere the body is visible. Governed by BDY.
Authority	Position, title, institutional backing	The king. Power from what the social structure grants. Effective within the domain of that authority. Loses leverage outside it. Title Tags amplify significantly.
Consequence	Demonstrated ability to follow through on a specific threat	The stage director. Power from controlling something the target needs. Effective specifically against people who need what is being threatened. Useless against those who don't care.

Insight → Tier 2 Branches

Tier 2 Skill	Domain	Notes
Shame	Seeing the gap between claimed and actual self and making it visible	Requires Insight to identify the gap. Requires Intimidate or Deceive to leverage it effectively. Applies Embarrassed and Exposed on success.
Resolve	Knowing your own position so clearly that pressure slides off	Deeper self-knowledge used as social defense. The character who has examined their own beliefs resists attempts to destabilize them.

Investigate → Tier 2 Branches

Tier 2 Skill	Domain	Notes
Observe	Passive wider-range perception — sounds, smells, motion, distant features	Scanning rather than searching. Noticing what changes in the environment without active effort. Threat detection at range.
Search	Active close-range investigation of a specific area	Methodical examination. Finding hidden objects, concealed passages, planted evidence, traps.
Appraise	Determining true value, quality, or nature of an object or situation	Active examination to understand what something actually is versus what it appears to be. Close range. Requires knowing what you're looking at.
Track	Following evidence of passage over distance and time	Reading signs left behind. Crosses into Hunting profession territory — requires both Investigate and knowledge of what you're tracking.

Tier 3 — Known Branches

Tier 3 branches are established where they have been developed. More will emerge through play.

Tier 3 Skill	Requires	Domain
Leadership	Inspiring Tier 2 Level 2	Coordinated group direction. Command structure. Tactical coordination of multiple people toward a shared goal. The lieutenant, the general, the guild master.

PART V — STATUS EFFECTS IN SOCIAL ENCOUNTERS

Unified Vocabulary

Status effects are not divided into combat and social categories. Most effects apply in both contexts. The effect description defines the mechanic. Context determines what it looks like narratively.

Status Effects with Primary Social Application

Effect	Social Context	Combat Context
Fear	Target must spend AP avoiding confrontation with the source. Breaks social engagement.	Target must spend AP moving away from source up to specified range.
Charmed	Target is favorable to charmer. Social defenses reduced. Will act on charmer's behalf.	Target becomes friendly to charmer and allies.
Enrage	+2 to social attacks, -2 to social defense per stack. Enraged debaters swing harder but leave themselves open.	+2 attack, -2 defense per stack.
Demoralize	Reduces Max SP. Sustained social pressure exhausts nerve the same way combat does.	Reduces current and Max SP by 2 per stack.
Confuse	Reduces MP as rational position fractures under logical pressure.	Lose MP equal to AP spent per stack.
Inspire	Grants SP equal to AP spent. Core Bard and Commander output in both contexts.	Same mechanic.
Distract	Lowers social defense. Prepared responses fail.	-4 to Block and Dodge per stack.
Disorient	Lowers social attack rolls. Target cannot form coherent responses.	-4 to attacks per stack.
Pacify	Cannot take aggressive social actions. Has been genuinely moved to non-aggression.	Cannot attack.
Silenced	Cannot make verbal social actions. Must rely on physical presence or wait.	Cannot activate verbal components.

Social Status Effects — Revised Definitions

These three effects have both social and combat applications. They are not social-only.

Effect	Full Definition
Embarrassed	–2 to all defense rolls per stack — social and combat both. A character made to feel small flinches in a fight the same way they flinch in an argument. Upkeep: remove a stack. A successful social action of any kind removes 1 additional stack.
Exposed	–8 per stack to Deception rolls and Stealth rolls. Reduces critical hit range against the character who applied Exposed by 1 per stack. A revealed person cannot hide what has been revealed. Upkeep: remove a stack. Must be addressed narratively to remove fully.
Enthralled	Movement actions must move toward the source of enthrallment. Cannot take hostile actions against the source. May only act against targets within field of vision while facing the source. Applies in combat and social encounters equally. Stacks remove when source takes hostile action against target or target takes any damage. Upkeep: remove a stack.

PART VI — RAPPORT

What Rapport Is

Rapport is not a character stat. It is a property of the relationship between two specific characters — it belongs to neither party individually but to the connection between them. A character does not have Rapport. They have Rapport with someone.

Rapport is tracked on the relationship record, not the character sheet. Player characters interacting with each other may set their mutual Rapport directly at any value — reflecting established history, prior agreements, or the nature of their relationship entering play.

The Rapport Scale

Rapport uses a 5^{Tier} exponential threshold. Each tier requires significantly more investment to reach than the last. Early goodwill is easy. Genuine devotion is a life's work.

Tier	Cumulative Threshold	Label	Description	Social Roll Effect
T1	5	Cordial	Polite and mildly interested. Basic goodwill.	Normal rolls
T2	25	Friendly	Actively willing to help when convenient.	+1 to social rolls that benefit them
T3	125	Warm	Genuinely likes and favors you. Will go out of their way.	+1 to all beneficial social rolls
T4	625	Trusted	Deep respect. Will take real risks on your behalf.	+2 to all beneficial social rolls
T5	3,125	Devoted	Loyal and emotionally attached. Extraordinary bond.	+4 to all beneficial social rolls
T6+	5^{Tier} continuing	Beyond Devoted	No additional mechanical bonuses. Pure narrative weight.	As T5
0	—	Neutral	No preconceptions. The starting point for strangers.	Normal rolls
-T1	-5	Wary	Slightly guarded or skeptical.	-1 to all beneficial social rolls
-T2	-25	Cold	Distrustful or disinterested.	-2 to all beneficial social rolls
-T3	-125	Hostile	Oppositional. Will actively undermine.	-3 to all beneficial social rolls
-T4	-625	Enemy	Openly antagonistic. Will act against you.	-4 to all beneficial social rolls
-T5	-3,125	Mortal Foe	Hatred. Will dedicate resources to your harm.	-8 to all beneficial social rolls

Modifying Rapport

A successful social roll modifies Rapport by the margin of the roll. A margin of 15 on a Persuade adds 15 Rapport to the relationship. A critical failure — losing the social roll by 10 or more — reduces Rapport by 5.

Discovered deception reduces Rapport by the original deception margin plus the discovery roll margin. Being caught in a significant lie is proportionally damaging.

Rapport-building actions generate Rapport directly. Result-getting actions like Intimidate and Leverage do not generate Rapport — they produce immediate outcomes at the cost of the relationship.

PART VII — FLAGGED FOR FUTURE DEVELOPMENT

The following elements are established in concept but require further development before they are fully playable.

- **Full Tier 1–5 skill blocks** for each of the eight base social skills — Inspire, Seduce, Persuade, Deceive, Intimidate, Insight, Investigate, Resolve.
- **Tier 3+ branching** for all skill tracks beyond Leadership. Tier 3 expressions of Debate, Rhetoric, Presence, Consequence, Concealment, Misrepresentation, and others.
- **Insight deeper branching** beyond Shame and Resolve. What else emerges from the capacity to read people and situations accurately at higher tiers.
- **Deception placement** within the chakra framework. Deception resists clean chakra assignment — it can emerge from Pride, Sloth, Greed, or Lust. It may remain a cross-cutting skill rather than chakra-aligned.
- **Novice chakra skill blocks** — Survival, Desire, Willpower, Courage, Discovery, Observation, Wisdom — fully written as five-level skills.
- **Tier 4 and 5 social mastery** — what kingdom-tier social capability looks like mechanically.
- **Emotional Affinity formal interaction rules** — how Affinity rank adds to social skill rolls when both are held in the same chakra channel.
- **Cultural Norm Tags** — how cultural knowledge modifies social rolls in unfamiliar cultural contexts.
- **Title Tags** — full mechanics for revocable, semi-permanent, and permanent title Tags and their social effects.